

B2B SALES ESSENTIALS

B2B Sales Essentials — Level 1 — Day 1: Know the Client: Research, Target Accounts, and a Reason to Reach Out

Study guide · Self-study

Level 1 · Day 1: Know the Client: Research, Target Accounts, and a Reason to Reach Out

How to Use This Guide

This guide is for you, working alone. Day 1 of Level 1 sets the foundation for everything that follows: before you speak to a business client, you understand their business well enough to say something true and useful.

Read it in one sitting. Write your answers to the "What Would You Say?" exercises before you look at the Model Answers at the end. The models are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you.

Keep a page of notes as you go. By the end you will have a short target account list and a real reason to reach out to each business on it. That list is your working material for the rest of Level 1.

This guide gives you research habits, a way to find and rank target accounts, and a structure for turning research into one relevant opening reason. It does not cover the first call itself; you will practice that on Day 2.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: How to research a B2B client's business model, industry pressures and likely priorities, and how to use that research to choose target accounts and build a reason to reach out.

Attitude: Research first, contact second. A relevant reason to reach out is earned by understanding the client's business, not by a clever phrase.

Skill: You can build a short target account list and write one specific, checkable reason to reach out to each business on it.

Upskill: You can test your research hypothesis against a real client conversation, note where your reading of their priorities was wrong, and correct it for the next contact.

Research Before You Speak: Why It Changes Everything

Think about the last time a seller contacted you. Within a few seconds you made a silent judgment: is this about me, or about them? Business buyers make the same judgment, faster and with less patience, because their day is full of interruptions.

The first silent question in anyone's mind is whether the contact is safe and relevant. A seller who opens with a generic pitch answers neither. A seller who opens with one true observation about the client's business answers both at once.

That is why research is a sales skill, not paperwork. It gives you the one thing that earns attention: relevance.

The psychology is simple. A business buyer's attention is a scarce resource, and their brain protects it with a reflex. When a message looks like every other sales message, it gets sorted into the same mental pile and dismissed before it is read or heard. When something in the message is clearly and specifically about their business, the reflex pauses. They think: this person has actually looked at us. That pause is the opening you need.

There is a second reason. Good research changes what you say, not just how you say it. Once you know how a business makes money, you can describe a problem in their language. You can guess what they are measured on. You can name a pressure they recognize.

You will not be right every time. That is expected. Treat your reading of the client as a hypothesis, a best guess to be checked, never a verdict. Carry it into the conversation as something to test, not something to announce. A seller who says "I noticed your depots in three regions — I may have that wrong" sounds careful and credible. A seller who announces "your logistics cost is too high" sounds like they have already decided and are not listening.

Read the Business Model: How This Company Makes Money

Start with the simplest question: how does this business make money? Everything else follows from it.

Look at three things.

What they sell. A product, a service, a subscription, a project. A company that sells to other businesses thinks differently from one that sells to consumers.

Who pays them, and when. A subscription business earns money steadily and worries about renewal and churn. A project business earns money in lumps and worries about utilization — keeping paid people busy. A retailer earns at the till and worries about stock and footfall.

What it costs them to deliver. People, materials, equipment, warehouses, software, subcontractors. A business with heavy fixed costs cares about volume. A business with heavy people costs cares about productivity per person.

From these three, sensible priorities appear. A subscription company that loses clients often will care about keeping the clients it has. A project company with idle staff will care about winning the next job. A company growing into new regions will care about consistency across sites.

Write these as clues, not conclusions. "Probably cares about X because Y" is your working hypothesis. The client conversation is where you test it.

Watch out: research tells you what matters to the business in general. It does not tell you what matters to this one client, this quarter. Keep those two apart.

Industry Pressures: What Is Changing Around Them

Every industry has pressures that the people inside it feel every week: a shift in costs, a change in what buyers expect, a new competitor model, a slow-down or a boom. When you can name one pressure accurately, you sound like a peer. When you name the wrong one, you sound like you are guessing.

How to find pressures without industry expertise:

Read what the company says about itself. Their own website, announcements, and job postings tell you what they are focused on and where they are investing. A company hiring heavily in one function is telling you what it needs.

Read what the industry says. Trade publications and industry associations often explain the pressures in plain language. One article can be enough for the opening reason you need.

Notice changes over time. New locations, new products, new leadership. Change creates questions, and questions create relevant reasons to talk.

For each business on your list, write one pressure in a single sentence, in the company's language. "Retail groups in this segment are squeezing delivery costs as buyers expect faster turnaround" is usable. "They want to grow" is not.

Build Your Target Account List: Choose Fewer, Better

A target account list is the short set of businesses you choose to pursue, with a reason to believe you can help and a reason to reach out. Do not make it long. This early in your role, do this work on a small list.

A simple ranking approach, which you can run on paper:

Fit: does this business look like the kind of client your company serves well? Look at the clients you already have and note what they have in common — size, model, pressures.

Signal: is there a current reason this business might be thinking about a change? A new site, a new hire, a new product, a struggle described in public.

Reachability: can you find a plausible person to contact, and a way to reach them? A perfect fit you cannot reach is not a target for this week.

Priority: how valuable would this client be if it worked? You do not need a number. The judgment is enough at this stage: this one matters more than that one.

Rank each business on the four items, then keep the top few. Write, for each, one sentence titled "Reason to reach out."

Practice example: A new seller lists eight manufacturers. Three have announced new facilities in the last quarter and five have not. The three with a visible change rank higher on signal, so they take the top of the list. The seller writes for the first one: "Opened a second plant in March; likely needs consistent process across two sites." That sentence is the reason to reach out. It is a hypothesis to check, not a claim to win an argument with.

Watch out: no invented reasons. If you cannot find a true, checkable reason for a business, move it down the list. Do not fill the gap with a guess dressed up as a fact.

Turn Research Into One Relevant Opening Reason

You now have a single reason per account. Make it usable in a sentence.

A strong opening reason does four things. It is specific to that business. It is true and checkable. It points toward a question the client can answer easily. It explains why you are contacting them now, without pressure.

Compare these two.

Weak: "I'm reaching out because we help manufacturers improve efficiency."

Strong: "I saw your second plant opened in March. Businesses running two sites often tell me keeping the same standards across both is the hard part. What has that been like for you?"

The strong version names something real, connects it to a pressure the client probably recognizes, and asks one easy open question. The client can answer it in their own words. If the pressure is wrong, they will tell you, and that answer is useful too.

Why this works: a relevant, low-pressure reason gives the client a way to stay in the conversation by choice. They are not cornered; they are invited. The question at the end does the heavy lifting, because it hands the conversation to them.

You will learn the full structure of a first contact on Day 2. For now, keep the reason to one sentence with a question at the end.

Apply It in Your Role

Here is the habit as a routine you can repeat on any workday.

☐ Pick one target business from your list.

☐ Spend 15 minutes reading their website, recent announcements and job postings.

☐ Write one line on how they make money.

☐ Write one line on the pressure they probably feel.

☐ Write your one-sentence reason to reach out, ending in an easy question.

☐ Mark which part of it is fact and which part is your hypothesis.

☐ Repeat for the next business on the list.

If you are shadowing a more experienced colleague, ask them to review your sentences and tell you which one they would have written differently, and why. Feedback from one real sender beats ten more articles.

Keep the list somewhere you can see it. You will build on it for the rest of the week, and the notes you take now become your raw material for discovery conversations later.

What Would You Say?

Complete each exercise before you look at the Model Answers. Write your own version first. Keep your answers short: one or two sentences each.

1. A regional catering company makes money on events. Recent job postings show several hires for a new central kitchen. Write your reason to reach out in one sentence, ending with an easy question.

2. A software company has published three updates about client renewals. Write one sentence describing the pressure they probably feel, in their language, without claiming it as fact.

3. You cannot find any true, checkable reason for a business on your long list. Write what you would do with it, and why.

4. A colleague asks you to send a generic opening email to 200 businesses because "it saves time." Write what you would say to them, in plain words, referring to your own list.

5. Write your own sentence for one real business on your list, marking any part you are guessing about with a short note in brackets.

> **NOTES**
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> Write first, then check the Model Answers. Common mistake: stating your hypothesis as a fact. A careful seller marks the guess and checks it in the conversation.

Key Takeaways

Research is a sales skill, because relevance is what earns attention and keeps the conversation alive.

Start with how the business makes money. Its model suggests its likely priorities.

Name one industry pressure in the client's language, not yours.

Keep your target account list short and ranked by fit, signal, reachability and priority.

Write one true, specific reason to reach out per account, and end it with an easy open question.

Treat your reading of the client as a hypothesis to test, never a verdict to announce.

If you cannot find a true reason, move the business down the list. Do not invent one.

Quiz

Answer the five questions. Choose one option per question. The answers are at the end of this guide, after the Model Answers.

1. What is the main purpose of researching a business client before you contact them?
   - **A.** To build a long list of every business in your market
   - **B.** To find one true, relevant reason for the contact and a sensible way to describe their priorities
   - **C.** To prepare a full product presentation for the first call
   - **D.** To learn the exact price the client will accept
2. How should you treat your research conclusions about a client's priorities?
   - **A.** As verified facts you can state confidently in the first conversation
   - **B.** As a verdict, so you can skip asking questions
   - **C.** As a hypothesis to be checked and corrected in conversation
   - **D.** As something to keep secret from the client

3. Which sentence is the strongest reason to reach out?
   A. "We are a leading provider with many satisfied clients."
   B. "I wanted to introduce myself and our services."
   C. "I saw your second plant opened in March. Businesses running two sites often find keeping standards consistent is the hard part. What has that been like for you?"
   D. "Do you have five minutes to hear about our latest offer?"
4. You cannot find any true, checkable reason to contact a business on your list. What should you do?
   A. Send a generic email anyway, so you make contact
   B. Invent a plausible reason so the message sounds specific
   C. Move it down the list and focus on accounts where you have a real reason
   D. Contact their head office and ask them to explain the business
5. Why does ranking targets by signal help you as a new seller?
   A. It lets you skip research for the highest-ranked accounts
   B. It focuses your limited time on businesses with a current, visible reason to be talking
   C. It guarantees the client will buy
   D. It means you can use the same opening for every account

Upskill Challenge

Before Day 2, do this with real work.

Build a target account list of five businesses you can realistically contact in your role, such as accounts your team has passed to you, or accounts you have been asked to research in your first weeks. For each, write: how they make money, one pressure, and one reason to reach out ending in an easy question.

Then test one hypothesis with a real person, for example a colleague who knows the account, or a supervised conversation with the client if you have support. Note where your reading of their priorities was wrong, and correct it for the next contact. Write down which step felt weakest for you: the business model, the pressure, or the reason.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. Use them to check your thinking, not to copy the words.

1. "I saw you are setting up a central kitchen and hiring for it. Caterers who centralize often find the hard part is keeping quality consistent across events. What is driving the change for you?" Why it works: it uses a public signal, names a pressure the client probably recognizes, and asks a question they can answer easily.

2. "Software businesses publishing renewal updates are usually feeling pressure to keep existing accounts as growth slows." Why it works: it is written in the client's language, uses only public signals, and stays a hypothesis the client can confirm or correct.

3. You would move it down the list and move on. A reason that is not true and checkable damages your credibility when the client spots it, and a generic contact earns a reflex dismissal. Better to focus on accounts where you can say something real.

4. "A generic message to 200 businesses tells each of them nothing about themselves, and most will sort it out as sales before reading it. I would rather send fewer, each with one true reason. That gives us a better chance of a real conversation." Why it works: it explains the buyer's reaction in plain words and offers a practical alternative.

5. A model version: "You have opened three depots in two years (fact from their announcements). I would guess keeping stock visibility across sites is now harder than running one (my guess). What has that been like for you?" Why it works: it separates what is known from what is guessed, and lets the client confirm or correct the guess.

- Quiz answers:
- 1. B. Research exists to find a true, relevant reason and a workable reading of their priorities, not to build a huge list or win a price.
- 2. C. A hypothesis invites the client to correct you, which keeps the conversation open; a verdict sounds like you have already decided for them.
- 3. C. It is specific, true and checkable, describes a pressure the client recognizes, and ends with an easy question. The others are generic and about the seller.
- 4. C. Do not invent reasons. No true reason means the account is not ready for contact this week.
- 5. B. Your time is limited. A visible change or signal is the strongest indicator that a business may be thinking about something now.

> **NOTES**
>
> Write your own version before reading these. Common mistake: stating your hypothesis as a fact. A careful seller marks the guess and checks it in the conversation.

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